WHEN GENERALS FAIL

THE BATTLE FOR BUM-LA

Mao tse-Tung's detailed instructions for the campaign against India directed the PLA leaders to go for 'audacious action' wherever possible. China's initial assault on 7 Brigade was a clear indication that PLA tactics would be based on creating local superiority in the campaign by concentrating strength at decisive points and assaulting from different directions. The Indians, being rooted to defensive positions, would always face overwhelming odds in numbers; else the Chinese would simply not engage the positions.

On the morning of 20 October, Jemadar A. K. Roy and his platoon of Assam Rifles had watched in amazement as a workforce of approximately 1,000 labourers, protected by Chinese soldiers, had suddenly appeared at Bum-la (16,500 feet). Equipped with digging implements, they prepared the ground so that the flat terrain could be used as a forming-up area for assaulting troops. In the afternoon, the JCO had trekked to the 1 Sikh position on the IB Ridge (so named because of an old abandoned Inspection Bungalow), where he apprised Subedar Joginder Singh of the developments. Joginder, in turn, discussed the situation with the Delta Company commander, Lieutenant Hari Pal Kaushik, who was based at Topeng-la. It was decided that a section under Havildar Sucha Singh would return to the Assam Rifles post with Roy while at the same time second line ammunition would be ferried across to the IB Ridge.

Over the next two days the Chinese continued to feverishly build up their force at Bum-la. Just as they had insolently lit fires on the Thagla Ridge to keep themselves warm on the eve of the attack on the Nam Ka Chu, here too they conducted morning PT to emphasize their numerical superiority and send a message to the defenders.

As we have seen in the previous chapter, at 4.30 a.m. on 23 October, three red Very lights preceded a barrage of Chinese artillery and mortar fire